

Technology and New Decision Making Mechanisms in Community Government

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Community governance refers to the way a community reaches collective decision-making on issues related to the use of natural resources, allocation of financial capital, or the solution of conflicts, among others. Some important aspects of community governance are participation, transparency, and the preservation of information. San Jerónimo Purenchécuaro was founded in the 16th century, and it has a particular form of community governance, with records being kept in fragile and unorganised documents.

Introduction

The objective of this study is twofold. First, I investigate how decision-making processes happen at community level, and address participation and effectiveness of the decision making mechanism. Second, I explore how record keeping is done in the community, to identify present and potential issues that may put records at risk.

The questions I pose are: Can technology enhance the efficiency of community governance, address local issues, and consequently improve the quality of life in the community? And what are the implications for decision-making of technology adoption in decision-making processes, in particularly in the selection of authorities, and local governance structure?

I propose the creation of a communal digital archive for information organisation, preservation, and to contribute to continuity in governance. Additionally, I consider the introduction of new mechanisms for decision-making to address low and unbalanced participation.

Background

- Decisions are made via voting
- Voting is publicly observed
- Participation is low



From



To



San Jerónimo Purenchécuaro is a Purépecha village located to the northwest of Lake Pátzcuaro.

It has the political category of tenancy and belongs to the municipality of Quiroga in the state of Michoacán, Mexico.

The Purépecha are a group of indigenous people with a rich ancient culture, recognised by their pottery, textiles, and wood carving.

San Jerónimo Purenchécuaro Government structure



- Population: 1,981 habitants
- 1,082 females and 899 male
- 1,100 have commoner rights and obligations for community decision-making
- Literacy (age 16 or more): 88%
- Religion: 97% Roman Catholic
- Age: 0-14 (22%), 15-64 (60%), 65+ (17%)



Methodology

I use community records from 1911 to 2023, I investigate the decision making processes mechanism. I also used primary data on participation, processes, issues and effectiveness.

Community decision-making

- Historical methodology
- Ethnohistory
- Qualitative research using
 - 5 Semi-structured interviews
 - 32 Surveys
- Data: primary and secondary

Communal archive

- In agreement with the Mexican General Archives guidelines
- Respecting the requirements of
 - General Archives law
 - Federal Archives law
 - National Archives Council

Findings

Community decision-making process

- Key community issues are decided through community participation. This includes resource allocation and conflict resolution among others
- Participation in decision-making processes is low. Only between 5 and 10 % of the population participates in community decision-making
- Females tend to participate less than males, mostly because of costs and risk (see below)
- Participation is not anonymous, which is perceived as a source of cost/risk
- Cost/Risks include: financial stress, community responsibilities, social frictions, erosion of social network, retaliation.
- Anonymity is difficult to achieve as some topics are person or group specific

Communal archive

- Records are at risk of being lost due to poor storage conditions
- No classification system or order is used
- Consultation and use is difficult
- More transparency is needed

Conclusion

Community decision-making is complex, with important decisions that affect the community and its inhabitants taking place using a mechanism that

- Uses open voting which creates anonymity problems
- Misses useful information due to low participation
- Generates negative effects on participants related to financial and social costs and risks
- Allocation of resources and choices may not be optimal due to lack of proper incentives to participate

Proposal and next research steps

- Use of digital technologies to increase participation and improve decision-making processes
- Introduction of anonymous voting to promote participation
- Design a digital archival system to preserve the community decision-making information, with information properly ordered and classified
- The digital archival system can be replicated a low cost in other communities

References

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